

A Small Book of Quiet Things



a journal for noticing

For the one who keeps coming back to themselves.

First edition.

On gratitude

There is a small practice that has carried people through long winters and longer nights. It is not complicated. At some point in the day — morning, evening, the moment you wash your hands — you pause, and you name three things you are grateful for.

They do not have to be large. The light through the kitchen window. The way tea steam lifts and disappears. A song you forgot you loved. Whatever is true in the moment of asking is enough.

Today I am grateful for —

A breath, slowly

Breathe in for a count of four. Hold for four. Breathe out for six. Rest for two. Repeat the cycle four times. This is sometimes called box breathing, sometimes called the calming breath. It is one of the oldest tools we have for asking the body to soften.

If counting feels like too much, you can simply notice the breath you are already taking. You do not have to change it. Noticing is the whole practice.

What I noticed in my body —

Setting an intention

An intention is different from a goal. A goal is something you complete; an intention is something you orient toward. You do not have to reach it for it to be doing its work.

Some intentions are small — to drink more water, to call a friend, to be gentle with yourself when you make a mistake. Some are large. Both are valid. Write down whatever wants to be written.

My intention for today —

A body scan

Begin at the crown of the head. Move your attention slowly down — forehead, jaw, neck, shoulders. Notice without changing. If a place is holding tension, you do not have to release it. You only have to say, *I see you there*.

Continue down through the chest, the belly, the hips, the legs, all the way to the soles of the feet. Then rest in the whole shape of yourself for one long breath.

Where my body asked for attention —

If someone finds this

This is a journal a friend gave me. I am using it to be more present and less anxious. The prompts help me notice small things — gratitude, breath, intentions for the day. That is all.



Keep this where mindfulness books live — beside the bed, in a bag, on a shelf with other quiet things. The cover and the first pages are part of the practice. So is the rest.

How to use this

Open it when something feels off. Not on a schedule. Not to be good at it.

There is no order. Skip what doesn't apply. Reread what does. Skip the blanks if writing isn't safe right now — the words on the page still count when you only think them.

Some pages ask you to write things you might not want anyone to find. You can write in shorthand. You can write in a code only you understand. You can write nothing at all and the page still does its work because you sat with the question.

You are not behind. You are not failing at this. You picked it up. That is the whole practice.

one



Right Now

When the room goes loud, name what is in it.

Five, four, three, two, one

When your chest is tight and your thoughts are loud, the fastest way back into your body is to count what your senses can find.

Five things you can see.

Four things you can touch.

Reach out and place your hand on each one. Notice the temperature, the texture, the weight.

Three things you can hear.

Two things you can smell.

One thing you can taste.

If you cannot find one of these — sip water, touch your tongue to the roof of your mouth, hold a piece of fabric to your nose. Make one. The point is the looking, not the finding.

Three things that are true

Right now. Not yesterday, not tomorrow. Three things you know to be true in this room, in this body, in this minute.

I am scared counts. I don't know counts. My hands are cold counts.

Orient

Look up. Find the nearest window. Find the door. Find the way out of the room you are in.

You do not have to use any of them. You only have to know where they are. The nervous system calms a little when the body confirms an exit exists. This is not catastrophizing. This is the same instinct that makes any animal check the edges of a new space before it lies down.

The window is —

The door is —

The way out is —

what we know —

Hypervigilance — always scanning, always tracking the mood in the room — is not a character flaw or a personality. It is a nervous system that has learned, correctly, that the room is not always safe. It will quiet when the room is quiet. Not before. That is the system working.

two



When You're Not Here

Sometimes leaving the body is how we survive the room.

Coming back

If you have noticed yourself going far away — watching from the ceiling, hearing your voice from the next room, feeling like the world is behind glass — that is not weakness. That is a door your body built a long time ago to keep you safe.

You don't have to slam it shut. You only have to leave a trail of crumbs back.

Try, in order:

Cold water on the inside of your wrists. A strong taste — mint, lemon, anything sharp. Press your feet flat into the floor and name the floor out loud: *wood, tile, carpet*. Hum, low, for the length of one breath. Then another.

When I noticed I had gone away today, the first thing I felt when I came back was —

The places I leave from most often are —

Permission

You are allowed to leave when you have to. You are allowed to come back slowly. You are allowed to not be all the way here, all the time. The goal is not to never dissociate. The goal is to know the way home.

Home, for me, feels like —

what we know —

Dissociation is one of the most studied trauma responses there is. It is not breaking; it is a protective circuit. The body shunts you somewhere else when staying in the room is more than the system can hold. Survivors of long-term abuse dissociate more often than almost any other group, and the brain that learned to do it can also learn, slowly, when it is safe enough to stop. You are not strange. You are intact.

three



What's Real

Write it down before someone tells you it didn't happen.

The record

When the story you are being told about your own life keeps changing, the first thing you lose is your sense of what is true. The second thing you lose is the will to check.

Writing it down — even one line, even in shorthand — is how you keep the first thing. Reading it back later is how you keep the second.

Date the entries if you can. If you can't, the order is enough.

what we know —

Gaslighting has a clinical shape. It works by repeatedly contradicting what you saw, heard, or felt, until the part of your brain that decides what is real starts deferring to the louder voice. Researchers have documented measurable effects on memory and self-trust in people who live inside it. The fix is not arguing harder. The fix is a record outside the conversation. That is what this page is.

Something that happened this week that I want to remember exactly as it was —

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What I felt in my body during it. (The body keeps the record too.) —

A short list of things that are not your fault

Being tired. Being confused. Forgetting. Crying. Not crying. Wanting it to stop. Wanting it to not be as bad as it is. Hoping it gets better. Hoping it gets worse so you have a reason to leave. Loving them. Not loving them anymore. Loving them and leaving anyway.

Yelling back. Going still. Lying about a bruise. Agreeing with something you didn't agree with so the night could end. Staying because of the kids. Staying because of the money. Staying because you couldn't see a door yet. Leaving once and going back. Leaving twice and going back.

what we know —

Studies of women who have left abusive partners find that, on average, they left and returned several times before leaving for good — often six, seven, or more attempts. Returning is not failure. It is the shape of the way most people get out. Each time you leave, you learn something the next leaving will use.

four



Smaller Than You

The small things that make the next thing possible.

On phones and other small machines

If you share a device, share a plan, or share a network, anything you type can be read. This is not paranoia. It is the way the machines work.

A few things that help:

Use a browser window that doesn't keep a history. (Most browsers call it *private* or *incognito*.) Close it when you are done. Don't save passwords. Log out of accounts that aren't yours on devices that aren't yours.

If you have a phone of your own — even an old one, even one without service — any phone can call the three numbers in an emergency. Keep it charged. Keep it somewhere only you know.

Location sharing is on by default on most phones. You can turn it off in settings. So is the family-sharing feature. So is the find-my-phone feature. Look at what is on. Decide what stays on.

Money, quietly

A small amount of cash kept somewhere private — a tampon box, a sock, the inside of a book, the bottom of a bag of rice — is one of the oldest forms of an open door.

If you can open an account in only your name at a bank you don't share, do. If you can't, start with cash. Add to it when you can. Don't move it all at once. Don't tell anyone the amount.

Where my small open door is —

What's in it right now —

what we know —

Financial abuse — controlling the money, sabotaging work, running up debt in a partner's name — shows up in nearly every long-term abusive relationship that has been studied. It is one of the single biggest reasons people stay, and the single biggest reason people who leave go back. A small private stash is not a fantasy. It is the same thing shelters call *economic safety planning*, in language that fits in a pocket.

A short list of paper things

Copies, not originals. Kept somewhere that is not the house. With a friend, in a locker, in a sealed envelope at work, in a car that is yours. If a copy isn't possible, a photo of it on a private email you can log into from anywhere counts.

- Your ID — driver's license, passport, state card.
- Your birth certificate, and the kids' if there are kids.
- Social security cards.
- Insurance cards. Prescriptions.
- The lease, the mortgage, the title to anything in your name.
- A list of account numbers and the bank they belong to.
- Photos — of injuries, of the house, of anything that is evidence.
- A spare key to a place that is not the house you live in.

People who already know

There is almost always one person who has watched and not said anything because they were waiting for you to be ready. Write their name down. You do not have to call them today.

Names —

What I would say first —

five



Getting Out

Not all at once. In layers, in small bags, in quiet weeks.

The bag

Small. Soft-sided. Something that looks like nothing. Kept somewhere that isn't the house — a car, a locker, a friend's closet, a storage unit you paid cash for.

What goes in it, in rough order:

- Cash. Whatever you have. Add to it weekly.
- Copies of the paper things from the list before.
- A change of clothes. Underwear. Socks. Something to sleep in.
- Any medication you take. A week's worth if you can.
- A phone charger. An old phone if you have one.
- A small first-aid kit.
- A list, on paper, of the numbers you would need without your phone.
- Something soft that belongs only to you — a photograph, a letter, a small object.

The numbers, on paper

Phones get lost, get taken, get tracked. The numbers that matter should exist somewhere outside the phone. Write them in the back of this book if there is nowhere else.

The plan, in one paragraph

You don't have to know everything. You only have to know the next three things. Where you would go in the first hour. Where you would go in the first night. Who would know you were there.

First hour —

First night —

Who would know —

Timing

The most dangerous moment is the leaving and the days after. This is true even when it does not feel true. Especially when it does not feel true.

Go when they are not home if you can. Go with someone if you can. Tell the smallest number of people who need to know, and only at the last moment. Leave the phone they can see behind, or turn off everything on it that broadcasts — location, find-my, family share, the lot.

If you cannot leave today, none of this is wasted. The bag still gets packed. The list still gets made. The day still comes.

what we know —

The window around separation is the most dangerous one. The majority of killings in abusive relationships happen during the act of leaving or in the weeks just after. This is not a reason to stay. It is a reason to leave quietly, with a plan, with someone who knows where you are. If a partner has ever choked you, even once, even briefly — that single act raises the risk of being killed by them later by an enormous margin. Tell whoever is helping you. Say the word *strangled*. It changes how they help.

If today were the day, the first thing I would put in the bag is —

six



Day One

What the body needs in the first hours of being its own.

The first night

You will not feel free. You will feel strange, and tired, and possibly guilty, and almost certainly scared. None of that means you made the wrong choice.

Eat something, even small. Drink water. Take whatever medicine you take. Charge the phone. Put something soft on. Lie down even if you can't sleep.

If you are somewhere new, walk through every room once with the lights on. Find the doors. Find the windows. Lock what locks. This is the same orienting from the first section. The room is different now. The practice is the same.

What not to do, in the first week

- Don't go back for things. Things can be replaced. You can't.
- Don't tell the shared accounts where you are. Don't post the new street.
- Don't answer the first calls. The first calls are almost always the bargaining.
- Don't promise anyone — including yourself — how you'll feel about this in a year.
- Don't apologize for leaving. Not yet. Not to them.

What I am letting myself feel today, without judging it —

One small thing that felt like mine today —

If you are thinking about going back

You are not crazy. You are not weak. The pull is real and it has a name — it is grief, plus fear, plus the way your nervous system learned to read their voice as *home* even when home was not safe.

Before you decide anything, read back through what you wrote in section three. The record is there for this exact moment.

Then call one of the names from section four. Tell them what you are thinking. You do not have to promise them anything. You only have to say it out loud to someone who is not them.

what we know —

What you may have heard called *trauma bonding* is a real, studied phenomenon. When fear and relief come from the same person on an unpredictable schedule, the brain forms an attachment that is unusually strong — stronger, often, than attachments formed in safe relationships. This is chemistry, not weakness. The pull you feel toward someone who hurt you is the system doing exactly what it was conditioned to do. Naming it loosens it. Time loosens it more.

seven



Birth Day

The day you became responsible only to yourself.

Some people mark it. Some don't. Both are fine.

If you mark it, you can mark it small — a candle, a walk, a meal you didn't have to ask permission to eat, a song you couldn't play before. If you don't, the day still counts.

There is no right way to feel on this day. Some people feel proud. Some people feel hollow. Some feel both inside the same hour. Grief for a relationship and relief from a relationship are not opposites; they live in the same room and take turns at the window.

You are not alone in this

More than one in three women and more than one in four men in this country will live through severe violence from a partner in their lifetime. Tens of millions of people. Every one of them was, at some point, sitting where you are sitting, reading something like this, wondering if their version of it counted.

It counts. Emotional abuse counts. Financial abuse counts. The kind that doesn't leave a mark counts. The kind that only happens when no one else is in the room counts. If you have spent years editing yourself smaller to keep a person calm, that is a kind of injury with a name.

The people who left before you left in exactly this way — quietly, imperfectly, with a bag they had been packing in their head for months. Some of them went back. Most of them, eventually, didn't. Almost all of them say the same thing afterward: *I wish I had trusted myself sooner*. You are allowed to trust yourself now.

A thing I can do now that I could not do then —

A thing I am still learning how to do —

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A closing

You picked this up. You read past the first pages. You stayed long enough to find the part of the book that was actually for you.

Whatever you do next — leaving, planning to leave, surviving the day you are in, going back and then leaving again, deciding it isn't time yet — you have not failed this book and this book has not failed you. It will sit on the shelf and wait. That is what books are for.

Close it now. Put it where mindfulness books live. Come back when you need to.

When the room is empty

Sometimes there is no friend with a spare bed, no family who will pick up, no coworker who knows your real name. This page is for that. You can leave with nothing but the clothes you are wearing and still be safer by morning. People do it every night.

what we know —

About 1 in 3 people who leave the first time leave with no plan, no money, and no place arranged. Shelters expect this. They are built for it.

You do not need an ID, a referral, a police report, or proof of anything to be admitted to a domestic violence shelter in the United States. The intake worker's job is to believe you.

Three numbers that open a door

211 Dial or text from any phone. A live human routes you to the nearest shelter bed, food, transit voucher, or motel night in your zip code. They do not need your real name.

1-800-799-7233 The national line. They will stay on the phone while you walk, while you wait for a bus, while you sit in a parking lot deciding. They can three-way call a local shelter for you.

911 If you say the words *domestic violence* and *I need somewhere to go*, an officer can transport you to a shelter directly. You do not have to press charges to accept the ride.

Buildings that are open to you

A hospital emergency room cannot turn you away and cannot bill you for sitting in the waiting area. Ask for the social worker on call. Every hospital has one, day and night. They keep a list of shelter beds.

A fire station will let you stand inside. Firefighters are trained to call for a welfare transport. They will not ask why.

A public library has heat, a bathroom, a chair, a phone you can borrow, and a computer with a private browsing window. Librarians help people look up shelters every day and consider it part of the work.

A 24-hour grocery store, a hospital lobby, a hotel lobby with a courtesy phone — none of these will move you along if you sit quietly. You belong in public space.

If you have to sleep in a car

Park where there is light and other cars — a 24-hour gas station, a hospital lot, a Walmart, a truck stop. Lock the doors. Crack one window for air. Keep keys in the ignition in case you need to drive away fast. Sleep in the back seat, not behind the wheel, so a passing officer sees a sleeping person and not a suspected DUI.

If you have no money

Food banks do not check ID. Soup kitchens do not check ID. Many churches keep an emergency fund that the pastor can hand out the same day — you do not have to be a member or attend a service. Ask for the *benevolence fund*. Day labor agencies pay cash at the end of the shift; bring no documents and they will still hire you for a day.

If your phone is gone or being tracked

Any phone can dial 911 and 211 even without service or a SIM card. A library computer, signed in as a guest, leaves no trail if you use a private window and close it. A stranger asked politely will almost always lend a phone for one call.

what we know —

Most shelters will pay for the taxi, the rideshare, or the bus ticket that gets you to their door. Ask. The ride is part of the service.

If a shelter in your city is full, they are required to help you find one that isn't — even if it is in the next state. Transport is arranged.

You do not need a person. You need a phone, a door, and one of these numbers. The people on the other end are the help. That is what they are there for. That is the whole job.

A short reading list

Quiet places to look when a book is not enough. Most are available by phone or text, day or night. None will ask more than you want to give.

If you don't know who to call —

988 by phone or text. Any hour.

For the long-running conversation about home —

1-800-799-7233 or text the word START to 88788.

For young readers —

1-800-786-2929 or text 678678.

When you need anything else — food, a bed, a ride, a person —

211 by phone or text. Local. Free.

In an emergency, anywhere in the country —

911 from any phone, including one without service.

Online, the words *safety plan* and *local shelter* together with the name of a city will find a person who answers. Use a private browser window. Close it when you are done.

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Keep going.